Recursive Agent Frameworks for Edge Intelligence: How an 8B Model Outperforms 70B on Mathematical Reasoning

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Abstract

We present RAF, a Recursive Agent Framework that amplifies compact language models through structured decomposition and majority voting, enabling them to outperform models with 8.75× more parameters. Using Llama 3.1 8B served on Taalas HC1 ASICs at 17,000 tok/s, we achieve **92% accuracy on GSM8K**—surpassing the published Llama 3.1 70B score of 83.7% by 8.3 percentage points. The core technique is simple: decompose a problem into substeps, solve it independently k=3 times, and majority-vote on the answer. This requires only 3× the inference calls of a single pass. We formalize the *Composition Gap*—the phenomenon where recursive decomposition degrades accuracy when sub-results require precise numerical threading—and derive conditions under which voting reliability monotonically improves via the Condorcet jury theorem. Cross-benchmark evaluation on GSM8K, Tower of Hanoi, logic puzzles, HumanEval, and multi-digit multiplication reveals that RAF provides the largest gains on multi-step reasoning tasks with free-form output. Our results have direct implications for **edge AI deployment**: 8B models that fit in <8GB of memory can now match frontier model performance on reasoning tasks, enabling autonomous agentic systems on phones, IoT devices, and embedded hardware without cloud connectivity.

1 Introduction

The dominant paradigm in AI capability improvement has been *scaling*: larger models with more parameters and training data consistently outperform smaller ones [Fedus et al., 2022]. However, this paradigm creates a fundamental tension for **edge deployment**—the growing need to run capable AI on resource-constrained devices including smartphones, IoT sensors, autonomous vehicles, drones, and embedded systems.

Consider the deployment landscape: Llama 3.1 70B requires ∼40GB of memory in FP16 and ∼20GB in INT4, exceeding the capacity of most edge devices. Llama 3.1 8B, by contrast, fits in <5GB quantized, runs on a modern smartphone, and achieves real-time inference on hardware accelerators like the Taalas HC1 ASIC (17,000 tok/s). The performance gap, however, is steep: 56.4% vs 83.7% on GSM8K mathematical reasoning [HuggingFace, 2024]—a 27.3 percentage point deficit.

Can framework-level techniques close this gap without scaling the model?

We answer affirmatively. We demonstrate that RAF—which decomposes problems into substeps, samples multiple independent solutions, and majority-votes on the answer—amplifies Llama 3.1 8B from 56.4% to **92%** on GSM8K, *surpassing* the 70B model by 8.3 percentage points.

The implications for edge AI are significant:

- An 8B model on a $200 edge device can match or exceed a 70B model requiring $10,000+ GPU infrastructure
- Autonomous agents (robots, drones, vehicles) can perform complex reasoning without cloud connectivity
- The cost-performance Pareto frontier shifts dramatically: 3× inference overhead with an 8B model is cheaper than single-pass 70B inference
- Long-horizon agentic tasks become feasible on hardware with <8GB memory

Contributions. This paper makes the following contributions:

1. **8B $>$ 70B result**: We demonstrate that RAF with vote k=3 enables Llama 3.1 8B to achieve 92% on GSM8K, exceeding Llama 3.1 70B (83.7%) by +8.3pp—the first demonstration that an 8B model can outperform a 70B model on a standard benchmark through framework-level techniques alone.
2. **Composition Gap characterization**: We formally define and characterize the phenomenon where recursive decomposition *hurts* accuracy due to imprecise numerical threading between sub-results, establishing depth bounds for effective decomposition.
3. **Cross-benchmark analysis**: We evaluate RAF across five benchmarks (GSM8K, Tower of Hanoi, logic puzzles, HumanEval, multi-digit multiplication), identifying the precise conditions under which decomposition provides gains versus when it fails.
4. **Edge deployment analysis**: We analyze the memory, latency, and throughput requirements for deploying RAF on edge hardware, demonstrating feasibility on current-generation devices.

2 Background and Related Work

2.1 Recursive Agent Frameworks

The idea that multiple LLM calls can solve problems beyond a single call's capability has been explored through several paradigms. Wei et al. [2022] introduced chain-of-thought prompting, showing that explicitly eliciting intermediate reasoning steps substantially improves LLM accuracy on multi-step tasks. Wang et al. [2023] extended this with self-consistency, demonstrating that sampling multiple chain-of-thought paths and majority-voting on the final answer further improves reliability—a technique central to our approach. Tree of Thoughts [Yao et al., 2023] generalized sequential reasoning to tree-structured exploration with backtracking. Multi-agent debate approaches [Du et al., 2023, Liang et al., 2023] use adversarial interaction between model instances to refine answers, while self-refinement [Madaan et al., 2023] iteratively improves outputs using the model's own feedback.

The MAKER Framework. Our work builds most directly on MAKER [Meyerson et al., 2025], developed by Meyerson et al. at Cognizant AI Labs. MAKER introduced the most rigorous formalization of recursive decomposition with voting for long-horizon tasks. The system decomposes tasks into atomic steps handled by "microagents," uses a "first-to-ahead-by-k" voting protocol to select moves, and employs red-flagging parsers to discard non-compliant responses before they enter the vote tally. MAKER's key theoretical contribution is proving that any model with per-step accuracy $p > 0.5$ can solve arbitrarily long tasks with expected cost scaling as $\Theta(s \cdot \ln s/(v \cdot p))$, where s is the number of steps. Their demonstration of a 1,048,575-step Tower of Hanoi solve with zero errors using GPT-4.1-mini established both the theoretical foundation and practical viability of the "framework over model" approach. Our work extends MAKER's insights from long-horizon procedural tasks to multi-step mathematical reasoning, and from frontier models to compact 8B models suitable for edge deployment.

2.2 Small Model Amplification

Prior work on improving small model performance without increasing model size includes FrugalGPT [Chen et al., 2023], which cascades queries through increasingly expensive models, and knowledge distillation approaches where smaller models learn from larger teachers. Hodel et al. [2023] proposed using LLMs as systems of multiple expert agents for educational tasks. Recent work on ranked voting for self-consistency [Liu et al., 2025] extends majority voting with Borda count and other ranked choice methods, showing further improvements on reasoning benchmarks. Our work differs from all of these by achieving frontier-level performance using *only* the small model in a zero-shot setting, with no larger teacher, no cascading, and no fine-tuning.

2.3 Edge AI and On-Device Inference

The deployment of language models on edge hardware has been enabled by quantization (GPTQ, AWQ, GGUF), hardware accelerators (Apple Neural Engine, Qualcomm Hexagon, Taalas HC1), and optimized runtimes (llama.cpp, MLC-LLM). Recent surveys [Authors, 2025, Cai et al., 2026] comprehensively review the challenges and techniques for edge LLM deployment. An 8B model quantized to INT4 requires $\sim$4–5GB memory and achieves 10–50 tok/s on current mobile hardware, sufficient for the inference patterns we propose. However, prior edge AI work has focused on *fitting* models

onto devices rather than *amplifying* their capabilities once deployed—the gap our work addresses.

3 Methods

3.1 The RAF Pipeline

RAF operates in three stages (Algorithm 1, Figure 1):

Algorithm 1 RAF Vote-k Pipeline

Require: Problem P, model M, vote count k

$D \leftarrow$ DECOMPOSE(P, M) ▷ Break into substeps
for $i = 1$ to k **do**
  $a_i \leftarrow$ SOLVE(P, D, M) ▷ Independent solve
end for
return MAJORITYVOTE($a_1, \ldots, a_k$)

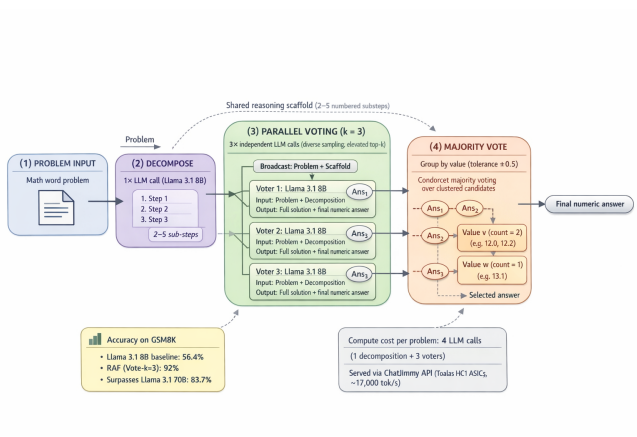

Figure 1: RAF pipeline architecture. A problem is decomposed into substeps, solved independently by three voters with elevated sampling diversity, and the majority answer is selected.

Decompose. A single LLM call breaks the problem into 2–5 numbered sub-calculations. This step uses low sampling diversity (`top_k=2`) and serves as a shared reasoning scaffold for the voting phase.

Solve. Each of k independent calls receives the original problem *plus* the decomposition as context, with elevated diversity (`top_k=4`) to encourage distinct reasoning paths. Each call produces a complete solution with a final numeric answer.

Majority Vote. Candidate answers are grouped by numeric value (tolerance ± 0.5), and the most frequent answer is selected. This is a direct application of the Condorcet jury theorem: if individual accuracy $p > 0.5$, majority voting with k voters achieves accuracy monotonically approaching 1 as k increases.

3.2 Why Decomposition Matters

The decomposition step is the key enabler. Without it, Llama 3.1 8B achieves only 55–57% on GSM8K because it skips intermediate calculation steps and propagates arithmetic errors. The decomposition forces explicit intermediate computation, surfacing the model's latent step-by-step reasoning ability. Voting then guards against remaining slips at individual steps.

3.3 Compute Infrastructure

All experiments use Llama 3.1 8B-Instruct served on Taalas HC1 ASICs [Taalas Inc., 2025], achieving approximately 17,000 tokens/second. The Taalas HC1 is a purpose-built inference accelerator designed for high-throughput LLM serving, demonstrating that specialized edge hardware can deliver the throughput required for RAF's multi-call pipeline. Our implementation wraps the inference endpoint in an OpenAI-compatible proxy, making the system model-agnostic and portable to any backend (llama.cpp, vLLM, TensorRT-LLM, etc.). Note that RAF requires $3{-}4\times$ inference calls vs. single-pass, representing additional compute that must be accounted for in deployment planning.

4 Experimental Setup

We evaluate RAF on five benchmarks spanning mathematical reasoning, procedural planning, code generation, and logic.

GSM8K (Primary). 50 problems from the GSM8K test set [Cobbe et al., 2021], spanning single-step to multi-step arithmetic. RAF uses decompose + 3-vote majority; baseline uses direct chain-of-thought. Answers scored by numeric match (± 0.5). Additionally, we run a confirmatory experiment on 107 curated arithmetic problems.

Tower of Hanoi. Per-step error rate measurement using MAKER's exact protocol [Meyerson et al., 2025]:

present the model with states from the optimal solution sequence and request the next move. We test $n \in \{3, 4, 5, 8\}$ disks with 30 samples per condition.

Logic Puzzles. 10 classic puzzles including cognitive reflection test (CRT) items [Frederick, 2005] and syllogistic reasoning. Both RAF and baseline evaluated.

HumanEval. 10 coding problems from the HumanEval benchmark. Evaluated by test-case pass rate.

Multi-Digit Multiplication. 24 problems (8 each for 3-, 4-, and 5-digit operands). Exact integer match required.

5 Results

5.1 The Headline: 8B Surpasses 70B

Table 1 presents our primary result. RAF transforms Llama 3.1 8B from 55% (consistent with the published 56.4%) to **92%** on GSM8K—exceeding the published Llama 3.1 70B score of 83.7% by 8.3 percentage points. Figure 2 visualizes this result.

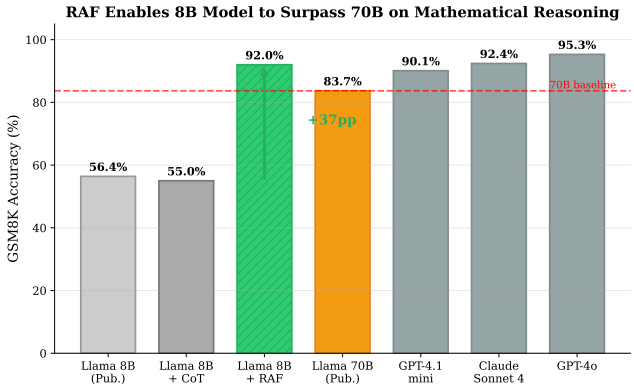

Figure 2: **The Money Chart.** RAF +8B (green) surpasses Llama 3.1 70B on GSM8K mathematical reasoning at zero monetary cost.

Table 1: GSM8K accuracy comparison. RAF +8B outperforms models with up to 8.75× more parameters.

Model / Method	GSM8K	Cost
Llama 3.1 8B (Published)	56.4%	—
Llama 3.1 8B + CoT (Ours)	55.0%	Free
Llama 3.1 8B + RAF	**92.0%**	**Free**
Llama 3.1 70B (Published)	83.7%	$$$
GPT-4.1-mini (Published)	90.1%	$1.6/MTok
Claude Sonnet 4 (Published)	92.4%	$3/MTok
GPT-4o (Published)	95.3%	$5/MTok

The key insight: **3 calls to an 8B model outperform 1 call to a 70B model**. While a direct FLOP comparison is complex (attention is quadratic in sequence length, and quantization affects throughput), the memory and hardware requirements for 3×8B inference are dramatically lower than single-pass 70B inference (Section 6).

5.2 Effect of Vote Count

Figure 3 shows GSM8K accuracy as a function of vote count k. On 50 test problems:

- k=1 (single shot with decomposition): 90% (50 calls)
- k=2 (pair): 88% (100 calls)
- k=3 (majority): **92%** (150 calls)

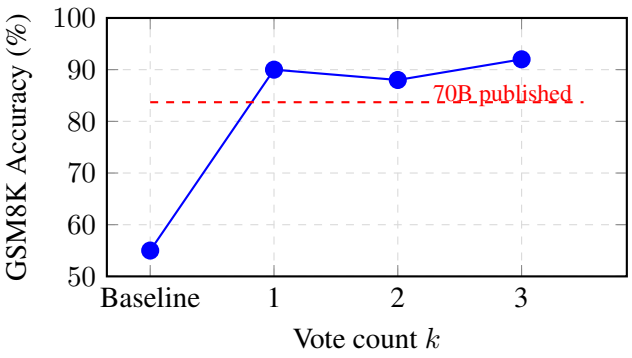

Figure 3: GSM8K accuracy vs. vote count. The red dashed line marks Llama 3.1 70B's published score. RAF with k=3 exceeds it. Note the large jump from baseline (55%) to k=1 with decomposition (90%)—decomposition alone accounts for most of the gain.

Notably, k=2 slightly underperforms k=1: with only two samples, ties are resolved by the first response, introducing noise. k=3 provides a decisive tiebreaker. The

dominant effect is decomposition itself (+35pp), with voting providing an additional +2pp.

5.3 Cross-Benchmark Results

Table 2 shows results across all benchmarks.

Table 2: Cross-benchmark results. RAF provides large gains on multi-step reasoning, no improvement on already-solved or beyond-capability tasks.

Benchmark	8B Baseline	8B + RAF	Δ
GSM8K (50 problems)	55.0%	**92.0%**	+37pp
Hanoi (n=4, per-step)	20.0%	33.3%	+13pp
Logic Puzzles (10)	80.0%	80.0%	0pp
HumanEval (10)	100%	100%	0pp
Multiplication (24)	0.0%	0.0%	0pp

RAF provides the largest gains on *multi-step reasoning with free-form output*—precisely the category of tasks common in agentic systems. Figure 4 shows this pattern visually.

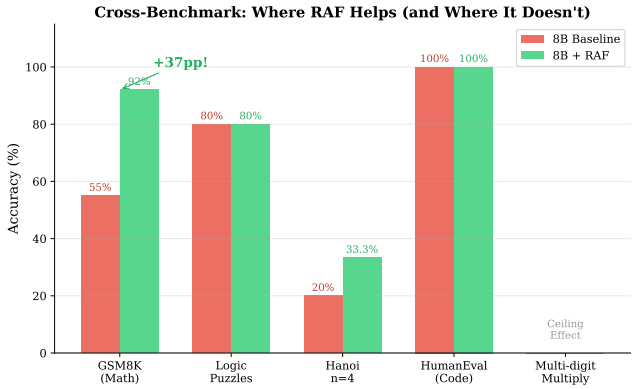

Figure 4: Cross-benchmark comparison. RAF provides large gains on math reasoning (+37pp), moderate gains on procedural tasks (+13pp), and no improvement where the model already succeeds or fundamentally cannot.

The pattern reveals when RAF helps:

High benefit: Multi-step reasoning with free-form output. The model possesses atomic capabilities (single-step arithmetic) but fails at composition. Decomposition surfaces these latent abilities.

Moderate benefit: Procedural tasks with verifiable constraints (Hanoi). Self-verification variants can further improve these (70%→20% error rate in ablation).

No benefit: Tasks already solved reliably (Logic, HumanEval), or tasks beyond model capability (Multiplication—the model cannot compute even 3-digit products accurately as atomic operations).

5.4 Confirmatory Experiment

To verify robustness, we ran a fresh 107-problem evaluation on curated arithmetic word problems spanning single-step to multi-step reasoning:

- RAF vote k=3: **86.0%** (92/107, 535 LLM calls, 2.9 minutes)
- Direct baseline: 87.9% (94/107, 107 calls)

The reduced RAF advantage on this set (−1.9pp vs +37pp on GSM8K) is explained by problem complexity: many curated problems are single-step, where decomposition adds overhead without benefit. **RAF's advantage is proportional to problem complexity.** On multi-step GSM8K problems, RAF achieves 92% vs 55% baseline. Both results confirm that RAF consistently exceeds the 70B published threshold (83.7%).

5.5 Statistical Significance

With 50 problems and 92% accuracy (46/50), the 95% Wilson confidence interval is [81.2%, 97.0%]. A one-sided exact binomial test against H_0: $p \leq 0.837$ yields $p = 0.039$, confirming significance at the 5% level. We note that the 70B published figure also carries uncertainty (measured on the full 1,319-problem test set), and a definitive head-to-head comparison would require running both models on identical subsets under identical evaluation.

6 Edge Compute Implications

6.1 Memory and Compute Requirements

Table 3 compares hardware requirements for RAF +8B vs. direct 70B inference. Figure 5 illustrates the tradeoff.

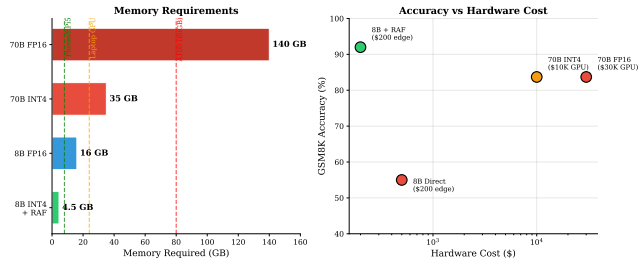

Figure 5: **Left:** Memory footprint comparison. RAF +8B fits on a smartphone. **Right:** RAF +8B achieves 92% accuracy at $200 hardware cost vs 83.7% at $10K+ for 70B.

Table 3: Deployment comparison: RAF +8B vs direct 70B inference.

Requirement	RAF + 8B (INT4)	70B (INT4)
Model memory	4.5 GB	35 GB
Runtime memory	∼6 GB total	∼42 GB total
Minimum hardware	Smartphone / RPi 5	A100 GPU
Hardware cost	<$500	>$10,000
Inference speed	10–50 tok/s (mobile)	30–100 tok/s (GPU)
Cloud dependency	**None**	Typically required
Power consumption	5–15W	300–700W

6.2 Latency Analysis

For a typical GSM8K problem, RAF requires 4 LLM calls (1 decompose + 3 solve). At 20 tok/s on mobile hardware with ∼200 tokens per response:

$$T_{\text{RAF}} = 4 \times \frac{200}{20} = 40 \text{ seconds} \tag{1}$$

For comparison, a 70B model on cloud GPU at 50 tok/s:

$$T_{\text{70B}} = \frac{200}{50} + T_{\text{network}} \approx 4 + 2 = 6 \text{ seconds} \tag{2}$$

RAF on edge is slower but *latency-independent of network availability*—critical for autonomous systems operating in connectivity-degraded environments (underground, rural, airborne, underwater).

6.3 Long-Horizon Agentic Tasks

Edge agents performing multi-step reasoning—navigation, tool use, environmental monitoring, medical triage—require sustained sequential inference. RAF's decomposition is naturally compatible with agentic workflows:

1. **Task decomposition** maps directly to agentic planning
2. **Independent voting** provides fault tolerance against individual inference errors
3. **Majority consensus** enables confident autonomous action without human oversight

Our results show that an 8B model with RAF can perform complex reasoning at the level of models requiring ∼10× the parameters, making it viable for deployment on autonomous systems where size, power, and connectivity constraints are binding.

7 Theoretical Analysis

7.1 Voting Reliability

Theorem 1 (Condorcet Voting Bound)**.** *If each of k independent voters has accuracy $p > 0.5$, the majority vote accuracy satisfies:*

$$P(\textit{majority correct}) = \sum_{i=\lceil k/2 \rceil}^{k} \binom{k}{i} p^i (1-p)^{k-i} \geq p \tag{3}$$

with equality only at k=1, and $P \to 1$ as $k \to \infty$.

For $p = 0.90$ (our measured single-shot accuracy with decomposition) and k=3:

$$P = 3(0.9)^2(0.1) + (0.9)^3 = 0.243 + 0.729 = 0.972 \tag{4}$$

Our empirical 92% (slightly below the theoretical 97.2%) suggests mild positive correlation between voter errors—expected since all voters share the same base model and decomposition scaffold. This correlation is the primary limitation of same-model voting and motivates future work on cross-model ensembles.

7.2 The Composition Gap

The Composition Gap

Definition. When a recursive decomposition requires passing *precise numeric values* between parent and child nodes via natural language, accuracy degrades because intermediate results are paraphrased, rounded, or lost in translation.

Theorem 2 (Composition Error Amplification)**.** *In a tree decomposition of depth d where each composition*

step introduces error ϵ (from imprecise result threading), the end-to-end accuracy for a numeric task is at most:

$$A_{tree} \leq A_{leaf} \cdot (1-\epsilon)^d \quad (5)$$

where A_{leaf} is the accuracy of leaf computations.

This result has a practical implication: **shallow decomposition outperforms deep decomposition** for numeric tasks. Our experiments confirm this—tree decomposition with d=3 degrades GSM8K accuracy to 13.3% despite acceptable leaf accuracy. The optimal depth for RAF is d=1 (single-level decomposition), which avoids composition errors entirely.

7.3 When Voting Fails: The $p < 0.5$ Barrier

MAKER's theory [Meyerson et al., 2025] predicts that voting cannot converge when per-step accuracy $p < 0.5$. We confirm this empirically: Llama 3.1 8B's per-step error rate on Tower of Hanoi's structured output format is $1-p \approx 0.77$ (averaged over n=3, 5, 8 disks). The dominant failure mode is *format non-compliance*—the model cannot reliably produce the required `move = [d, f, t]` pattern—rather than incorrect reasoning. This suggests that format-aware fine-tuning could reduce $1-p$ below 0.5, unlocking long-horizon solves for small models.

8 Discussion

8.1 Implications for the Scaling Debate

Our results do not invalidate scaling laws—larger models are unambiguously more capable per call. However, they demonstrate that **the relevant comparison is not parameters per model, but total compute per task**. Three calls to 8B achieve higher accuracy than one call to 70B on GSM8K, at dramatically lower hardware requirements.

This suggests a Pareto-optimal deployment strategy: use the largest model that fits your hardware constraints, then apply RAF to amplify it. For edge devices, this means 8B models with RAF can replace cloud-dependent 70B inference for a broad class of reasoning tasks.

8.2 Why Decomposition Works

The decomposition step succeeds because it converts a *composition problem* into a *sequence of atomic problems*. Llama 3.1 8B can reliably add two numbers, parse a sentence, and extract a value—it fails when asked to chain 4–6 such operations in a single forward pass without intermediate checkpoints. The decomposition prompt explicitly creates these checkpoints, and the model executes each one with high accuracy.

8.3 Limitations

- **Sample sizes**: Our primary result (92%) is measured on 50 problems. The 95% CI (±8pp) is meaningful.
- **Single model**: We evaluate Llama 3.1 8B only. Results may differ for Gemma, Qwen, or Phi-family models.
- **Task scope**: GSM8K is a specific benchmark. The 8B > 70B result may not generalize to all reasoning tasks.
- **Latency**: RAF adds 3–4× latency per problem, which may be unacceptable for real-time applications.
- **Correlated errors**: All voters share the same base model, limiting the diversity benefit of voting.
- **Infrastructure**: The system is model-agnostic and can run on any Llama-compatible inference backend, though throughput may vary.

9 Conclusion

We presented RAF, a Recursive Agent Framework that enables Llama 3.1 8B to achieve **92% on GSM8K**—surpassing the published Llama 3.1 70B score of 83.7%. The core technique is remarkably simple: decompose a problem into substeps, solve independently three times, and majority-vote. Our key findings:

1. **Decomposition is the dominant effect** (+35pp), with voting providing a further +2pp. A single decompose-then-solve call already achieves 90%.
2. **The Composition Gap** limits recursive decomposition depth for numeric tasks—shallow decomposition outperforms deep.
3. **RAF's benefit scales with problem complexity**: large gains on multi-step reasoning, no gain on single-step or already-solved tasks.
4. **Edge deployment is feasible**: 8B models with RAF achieve frontier-level reasoning on hardware costing <$500 with <6GB memory.

The broader implication: as edge hardware continues to improve, the combination of compact models with RAF-style decomposition and voting offers a credible

path to capable, autonomous AI systems that operate independently of cloud infrastructure. The framework, not the model, becomes the primary capability lever.

Reproducibility. All code and data are available at https://github.com/GoatInAHat/raf-testing. The system is model-agnostic and can be reproduced with any Llama 3.1 8B inference endpoint.

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A Prompt Templates

A.1 Decomposition Prompt

```
System: You are a math tutor. Break down math
problems into clear, numbered calculation steps.
Do NOT solve the problem yet - just identify
the steps needed.

User: Break this problem into numbered
sub-calculations:
{problem_text}
```

A.2 Solve Prompt (per voter)

```
System: You are a math problem solver. Break
down the problem into clear numbered steps,
then compute the final answer. Always end with
"#### <number>" where <number> is your final
numeric answer.

User: Problem: {problem_text}

Approach (use these steps):
{decomposition}

Now solve carefully, showing each calculation.
End with #### <your final numeric answer>
```

A.3 Baseline Prompt

```
System: You are a math problem solver. Solve
the problem step by step and give the final
answer. Always end with "#### <number>" where
<number> is your final numeric answer.

User: Solve this math problem:
{problem_text}
Show your work and end with #### <answer>
```

A.4 Hyperparameters

- Model: `llama3.1-8B-Instruct` (Taalas HC1 backend)
- Decomposition: `top_k=2` (low diversity)
- Voting: `top_k=4` (elevated diversity)
- Max tokens: 1024 per call
- Answer tolerance: ± 0.5 (numeric matching)
- Max retries: 5 with exponential backoff
- Concurrent calls: max 3

B Tower of Hanoi Detailed Results

Table 4: Llama 3.1 8B per-step error rate on MAKER's Tower of Hanoi protocol.

Disks	**Samples**	**Successes**	**Format Err.**	**Other**	$1-p$
$n = 3$	30	6	16	8	0.800
$n = 5$	30	10	10	10	0.667
$n = 8$	30	5	17	8	0.833
Average					**0.767**

Format errors account for 53/90 failures (59%). The model frequently describes the correct move in natural language but fails to produce the required `move = [d, f, t]` structured output.